

you fell in love with, the one who lit the initial fireworks. But here is where relationship due diligence becomes critical. In the third year, it's time to ask some tough financial questions—and carefully weigh the answers. What is your partner's credit rating? If the score is low, you deserve to know why. How much debt do they have? What is their monthly budget? This is also the time to draw up the hypothetical household budget you'd be operating under if you were to get married or live together, and to decide on specific financial roles. Every marriage requires certain day-to-day tasks—keeping track of accounts, paying bills, filing taxes—as well as longer-term responsibilities, such as investments and wealth management. The third year is when you decide who does what. And will that change as your relationship progresses? If your partner has certain money behaviors or inefficiencies that concern you, make an appointment with a financial advisor immediately to get a third-person perspective. Be honest with yourself and with your advisor. Is it the right choice to build a life with this person? If the answer is yes, pass Go and collect \$200. If the answer is no, move on. Far better to know you're not compatible now than 10 years down the road, once you've got a marriage, house and kids at stake.

By the way: if it becomes clear for any reason that you're never going to have children with this person, don't bother getting married. You can cohabitate for the rest of your life, but there's no need to enter into a contract. This was one of the most controversial points in my second book, but I stand behind it. A marriage contract sets up the structure and legal protection for your future family. If you're not going to have kids, what's the point?

Right now, you may be thinking, "Whoa, Kevin. I'm not dating seriously—I'm just having fun. What's wrong with that?" I'll tell you what's wrong with that: chances are the fun you're having is blowing a hole through your pocket. And if you're not planning for the future, how will you recognize Mr. or Mrs. Right? Even if you're only in your 20s, you should be actively identifying your goals regarding finances, career, partnership and family. If you want to be happy, you're going to need to find a mate who is in sync with you in each area. And if you want a successful 46-year marriage like my